

04

Najdorf Foundations and Move Orders

What 5...a6 actually does, when ...e6 or ...e5 belongs, and how ...b5 must be prepared.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will reach the Najdorf with a reason for every preparatory move and a safe response to White's sixth-move choice.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 019 | PAGE 4

Decode: The meaning of 5...a6*...a6 asks White to declare a plan; Black's next move must answer that declaration.*

LESSON 020 | PAGE 8

Play: The meaning of 5...a6*...a6 asks White to declare a plan; Black's next move must answer that declaration.*

LESSON 021 | PAGE 12

Decode: Choosing between ...e6 and ...e5*The central pawn decides the whole position; choose it after reading the pieces.*

LESSON 022 | PAGE 16

Play: Choosing between ...e6 and ...e5*The central pawn decides the whole position; choose it after reading the pieces.*

LESSON 023 | PAGE 20

Decode: When ...b5 is real*A wing pawn move must buy time, a square, or a file.*

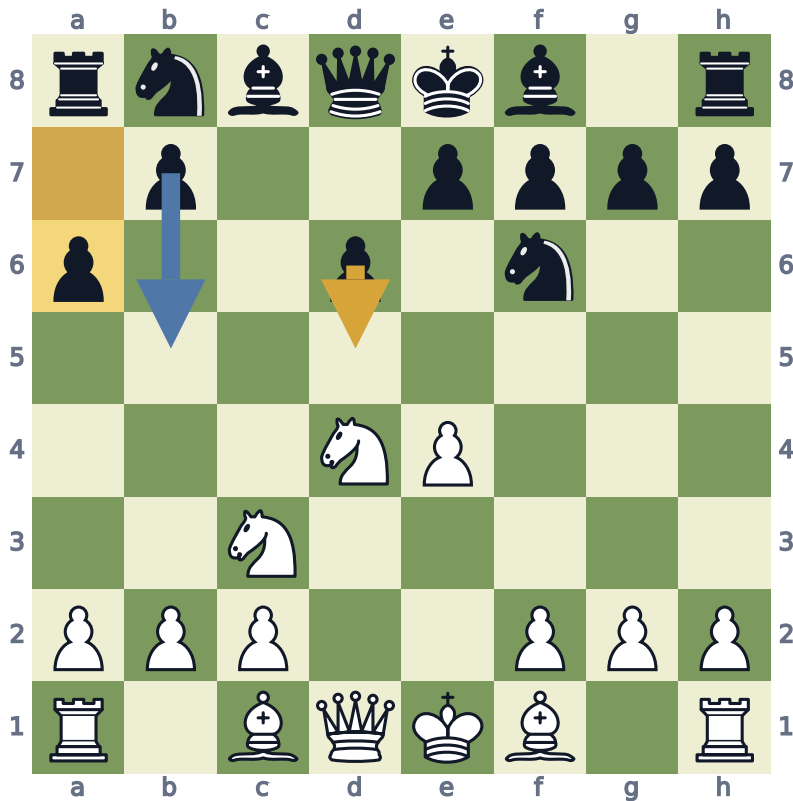
LESSON 024 | PAGE 24

Play: When ...b5 is real*A wing pawn move must buy time, a square, or a file.***VOLUME OBJECTIVE**

You will reach the Najdorf with a reason for every preparatory move and a safe response to White's sixth-move choice.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The meaning of 5...a6



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...a6 denies Nb5, prepares ...b5, and keeps pieces off a useful square. Its value is strategic flexibility rather than an immediate threat.

DECISION RULE

What did White's sixth move reveal about castling, pawn breaks, and the critical central response?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Read White's sixth move, choose the matching central structure, then expand only when development supports it.

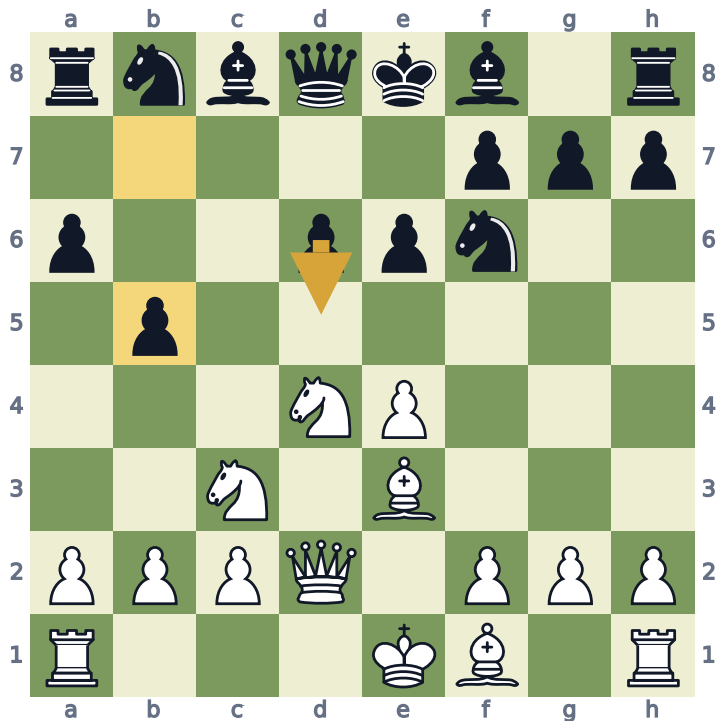
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses the extra tempo for a purposeful setup: Bg5, Be3, Be2, Bc4, f3, h3, or g3.

MEMORY RULE | ...a6 asks White to declare a plan; Black's next move must answer that declaration.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...a6 denies Nb5, prepares ...b5, and keeps pieces off a useful square. Its value is strategic flexibility rather than an immediate threat.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Read White's sixth move, choose the matching central structure, then expand only when development supports it.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White uses the extra tempo for a purposeful setup: Bg5, Be3, Be2, Bc4, f3, h3, or g3.

FAILURE MODE

Answering every setup with the same move order and walking into a refined attacking scheme.

DECISION TEST

Ask: What did White's sixth move reveal about castling, pawn breaks, and the critical central response? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

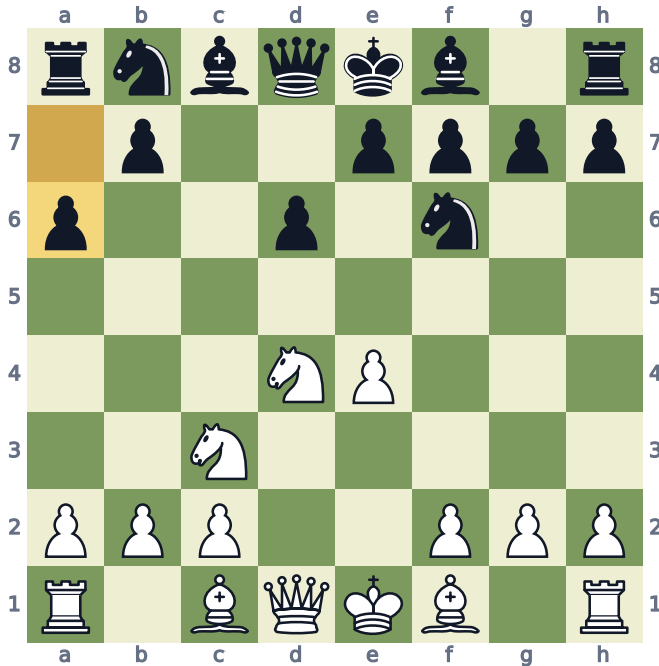
RULE | ...a6 asks White to declare a plan; Black's next move must answer that declaration.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be3 e6 7. Qd2 b5



- d4: White builds the Open Sicilian center and offers the d-pawn for rapid development.
- cxd4: Black releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...a6 denies Nb5, prepares ...b5, and keeps pieces off a useful square. Its value is strategic flexibility rather than an immediate threat.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

What did White's sixth move reveal about castling, pawn breaks, and the critical central response? White's resistance is: White uses the extra tempo for a purposeful setup: Bg5, Be3, Be2, Bc4, f3, h3, or g3. The line fails as a template when: Answering every setup with the same move order and walking into a refined attacking scheme.

STORE THIS | ...a6 asks White to declare a plan; Black's next move must answer that declaration.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

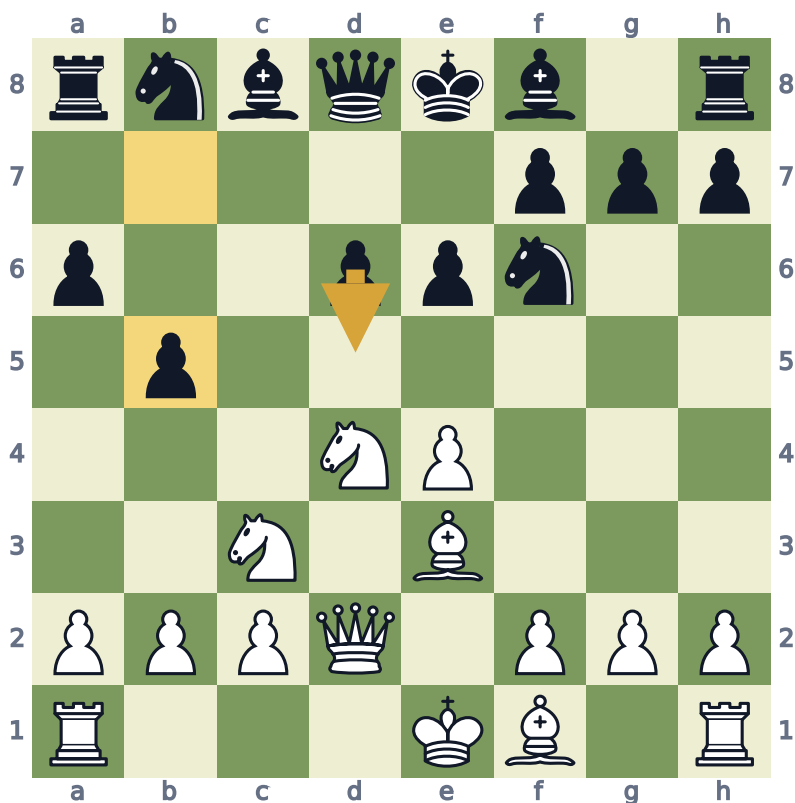
1. ...a6 denies Nb5, prepares ...b5, and keeps pieces off a useful square. Its value is strategic flexibility rather than an immediate threat. 2. Read White's sixth move, choose the matching central structure, then expand only when development supports it. 3. White uses the extra tempo for a purposeful setup: Bg5, Be3, Be2, Bc4, f3, h3, or g3. 4. What did White's sixth move reveal about castling, pawn breaks, and the critical central response? 5. Answering every setup with the same move order and walking into a refined attacking scheme.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 10 plies from memory, then replay: 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The meaning of 5...a6



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...a6 denies Nb5, prepares ...b5, and keeps pieces off a useful square. Its value is strategic flexibility rather than an immediate threat.

DECISION RULE

What did White's sixth move reveal about castling, pawn breaks, and the critical central response?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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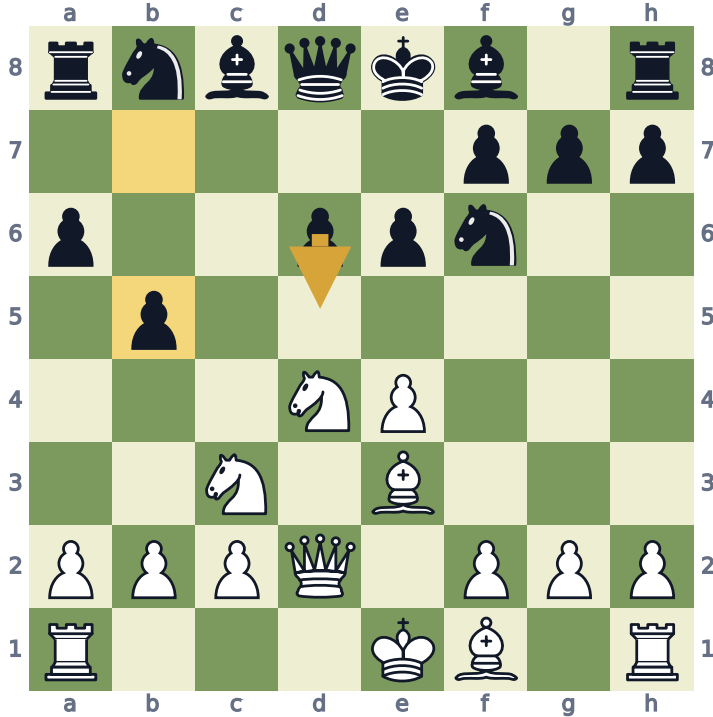
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White uses the extra tempo for a purposeful setup: Bg5, Be3, Be2, Bc4, f3, h3, or g3.

MEMORY RULE | ...a6 asks White to declare a plan; Black's next move must answer that declaration.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...a6 denies Nb5, prepares ...b5, and keeps pieces off a useful square. Its value is strategic flexibility rather than an immediate threat.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Read White's sixth move, choose the matching central structure, then expand only when development supports it.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White uses the extra tempo for a purposeful setup: Bg5, Be3, Be2, Bc4, f3, h3, or g3.

FAILURE MODE

Answering every setup with the same move order and walking into a refined attacking scheme.

DECISION TEST

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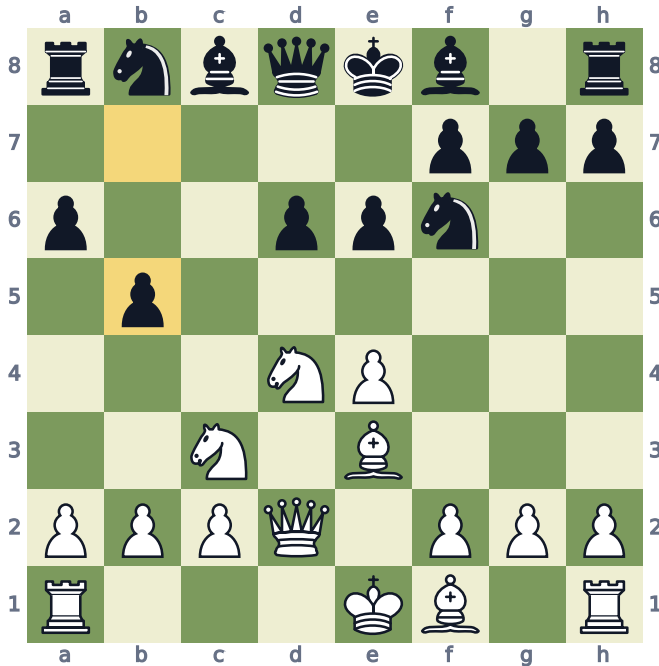
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be3 e6 7. Qd2 b5



- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- e6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Qd2: White coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.
- b5: Black starts queenside expansion and prepares files or a bishop diagonal.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...a6 denies Nb5, prepares ...b5, and keeps pieces off a useful square. Its value is strategic flexibility rather than an immediate threat.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

What did White's sixth move reveal about castling, pawn breaks, and the critical central response? White's resistance is: White uses the extra tempo for a purposeful setup: Bg5, Be3, Be2, Bc4, f3, h3, or g3. The line fails as a template when: Answering every setup with the same move order and walking into a refined attacking scheme.

STORE THIS | ...a6 asks White to declare a plan; Black's next move must answer that declaration.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

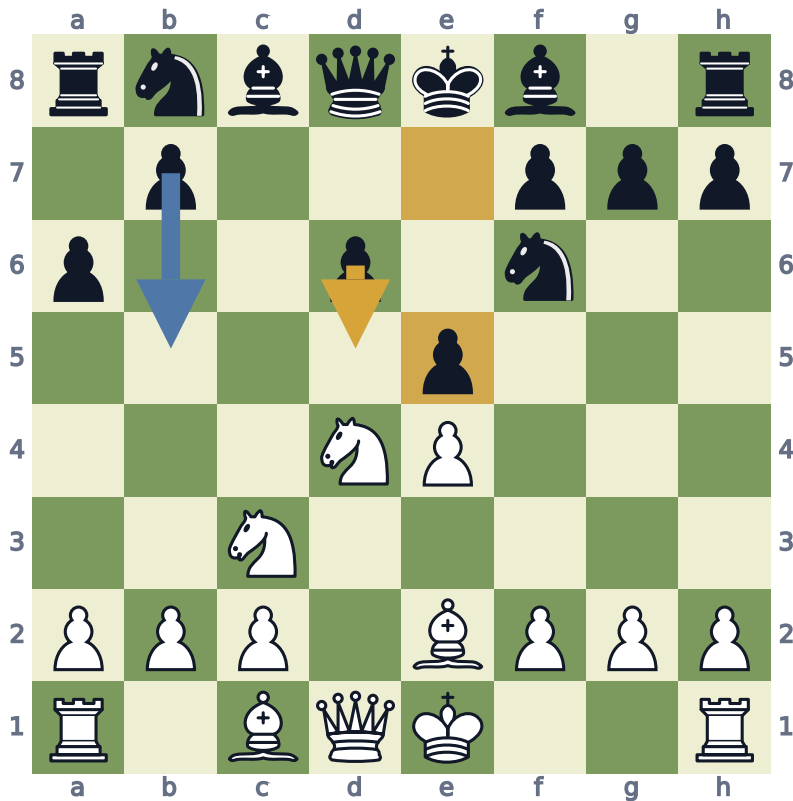
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be3 e6 7. Qd2 b5

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Choosing between ...e6 and ...e5

**WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS**

...e6 keeps d5 flexible and supports ...d5; ...e5 gains space and tempo but creates a permanent d5 outpost.

DECISION RULE

Which structure gives your pieces active squares while denying White a favorable break?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Select the center from concrete demands: piece placement, White's pressure, and whether d5 can be controlled.

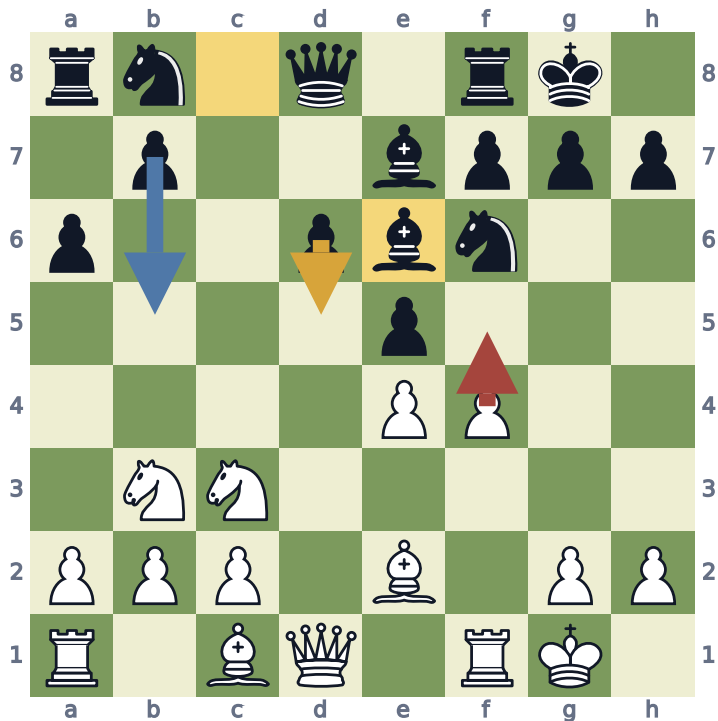
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White chooses plans that expose the price of the center: a space squeeze against ...e6 or Nd5 against ...e5.

MEMORY RULE | The central pawn decides the whole position; choose it after reading the pieces.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...e6 keeps d5 flexible and supports ...d5; ...e5 gains space and tempo but creates a permanent d5 outpost.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Select the center from concrete demands: piece placement, White's pressure, and whether d5 can be controlled.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White chooses plans that expose the price of the center: a space squeeze against ...e6 or Nd5 against ...e5.

FAILURE MODE

Choosing the familiar pawn move without checking whether White's setup was designed to punish it.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which structure gives your pieces active squares while denying White a favorable break? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

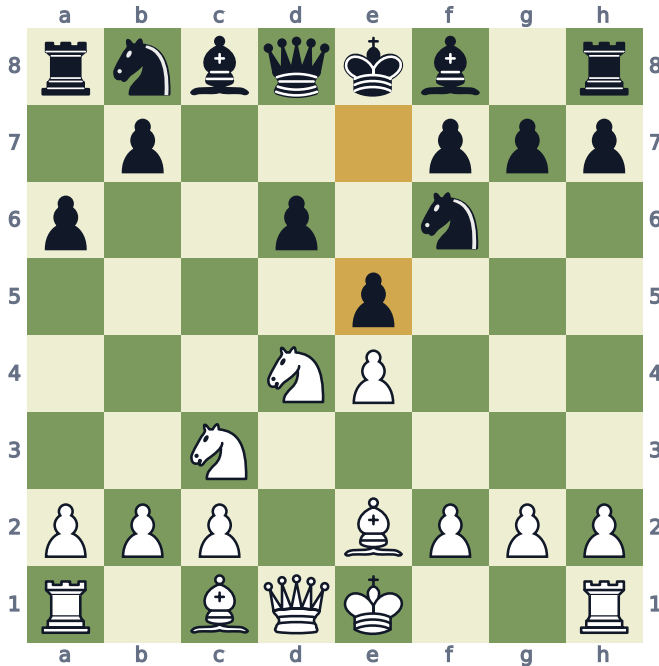
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. f4 Be6



- Nxd4: White releases tension by capturing on d4; recalculate the pawn skeleton, open lines, and the opponent's most forcing recapture.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- e5: Black gains central space and a knight tempo while accepting a lasting weakness on d5.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...e6 keeps d5 flexible and supports ...d5; ...e5 gains space and tempo but creates a permanent d5 outpost.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which structure gives your pieces active squares while denying White a favorable break? White's resistance is: White chooses plans that expose the price of the center: a space squeeze against ...e6 or Nd5 against ...e5. The line fails as a template when: Choosing the familiar pawn move without checking whether White's setup was designed to punish it.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

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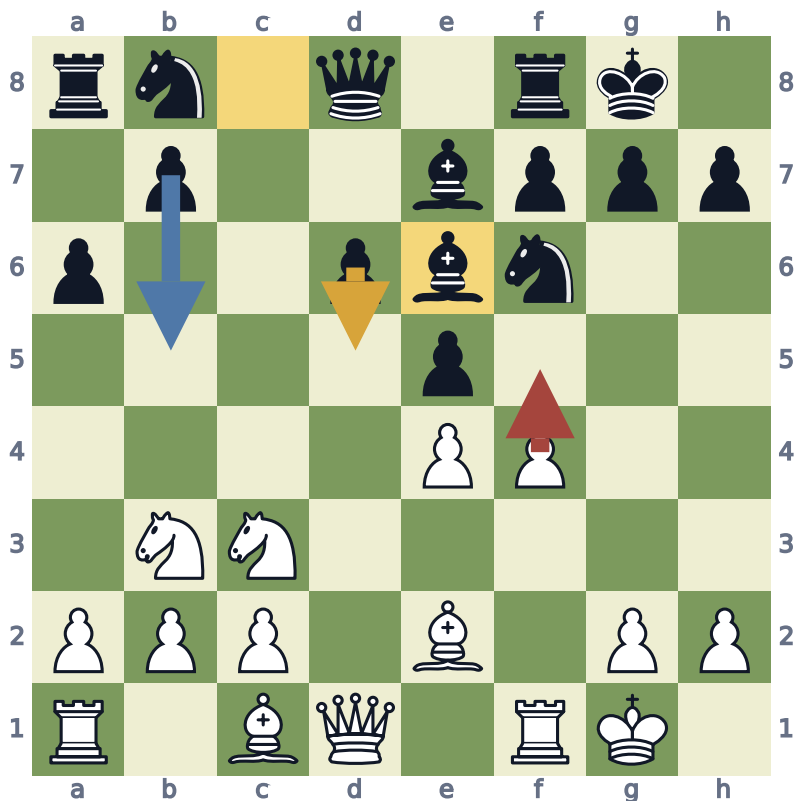
1. ...e6 keeps d5 flexible and supports ...d5; ...e5 gains space and tempo but creates a permanent d5 outpost. 2. Select the center from concrete demands: piece placement, White's pressure, and whether d5 can be controlled. 3. White chooses plans that expose the price of the center: a space squeeze against ...e6 or Nd5 against ...e5. 4. Which structure gives your pieces active squares while denying White a favorable break? 5. Choosing the familiar pawn move without checking whether White's setup was designed to punish it.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Choosing between ...e6 and ...e5



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...e6 keeps d5 flexible and supports ...d5; ...e5 gains space and tempo but creates a permanent d5 outpost.

DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Select the center from concrete demands: piece placement, White's pressure, and whether d5 can be controlled.

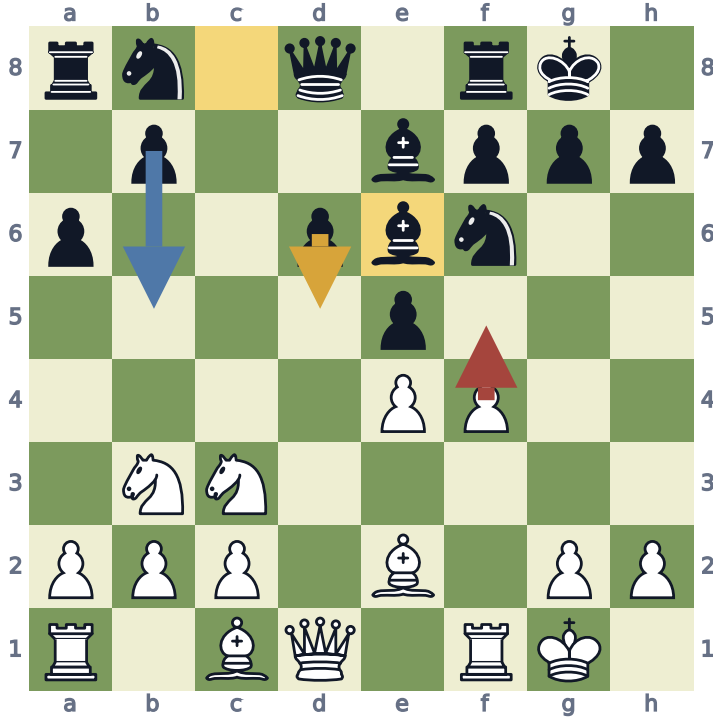
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White chooses plans that expose the price of the center: a space squeeze against ...e6 or Nd5 against ...e5.

MEMORY RULE | The central pawn decides the whole position; choose it after reading the pieces.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...e6 keeps d5 flexible and supports ...d5; ...e5 gains space and tempo but creates a permanent d5 outpost.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Select the center from concrete demands: piece placement, White's pressure, and whether d5 can be controlled.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White chooses plans that expose the price of the center: a space squeeze against ...e6 or Nd5 against ...e5.

FAILURE MODE

Choosing the familiar pawn move without checking whether White's setup was designed to punish it.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which structure gives your pieces active squares while denying White a favorable break? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

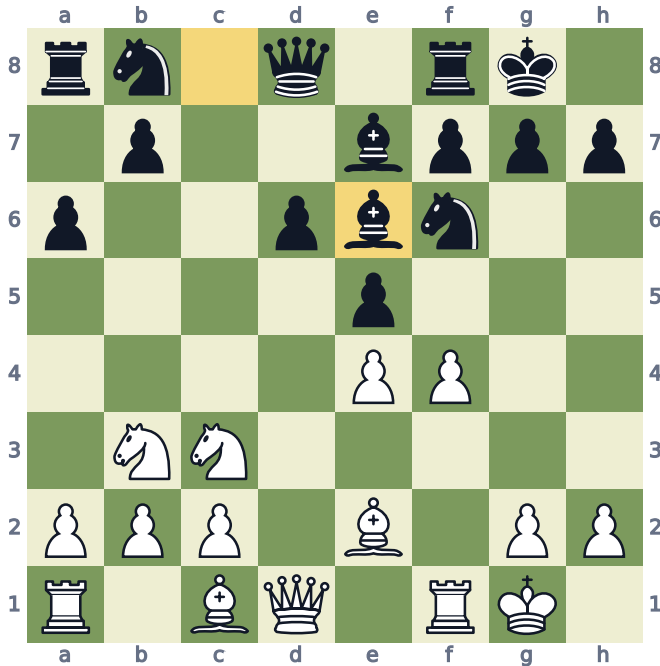
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. f4 Be6



- Nb3: White reroutes a knight to b3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- f4: White claims kingside space and announces e5 or f5 attacking ideas.
- Be6: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...e6 keeps d5 flexible and supports ...d5; ...e5 gains space and tempo but creates a permanent d5 outpost.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which structure gives your pieces active squares while denying White a favorable break? White's resistance is: White chooses plans that expose the price of the center: a space squeeze against ...e6 or Nd5 against ...e5. The line fails as a template when: Choosing the familiar pawn move without checking whether White's setup was designed to punish it.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

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ANSWER KEY

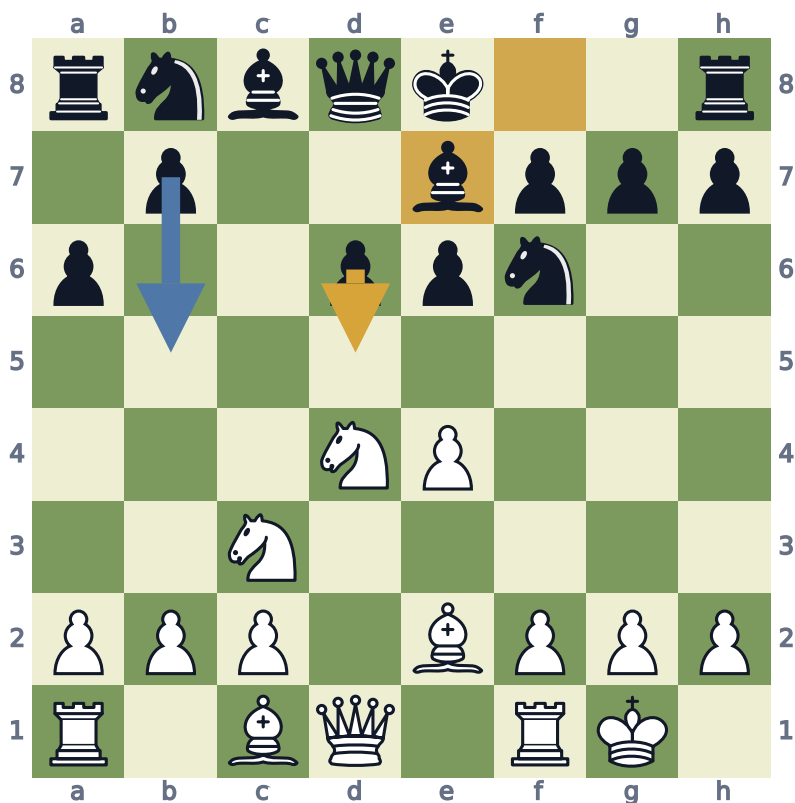
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. f4 Be6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: When ...b5 is real



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Queenside expansion is useful when it gains space, drives a piece, supports ...Bb7, or creates a file; otherwise it may expose b6 and a6.

DECISION RULE

If ...b5 is played, what concrete improvement arrives on the next move?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Prepare ...b5 with piece control, king safety, and an answer to e5 or a4; use ...b4 only when the knight displacement matters.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White restrains with a4 or opens the center while Black spends tempi on pawns.

MEMORY RULE | A wing pawn move must buy time, a square, or a file.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White restrains with a4 or opens the center while Black spends tempi on pawns.

FAILURE MODE

Treating ...b5 as a compulsory Najdorf badge rather than a calculated operation.

DECISION TEST

Ask: If ...b5 is played, what concrete improvement arrives on the next move? Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

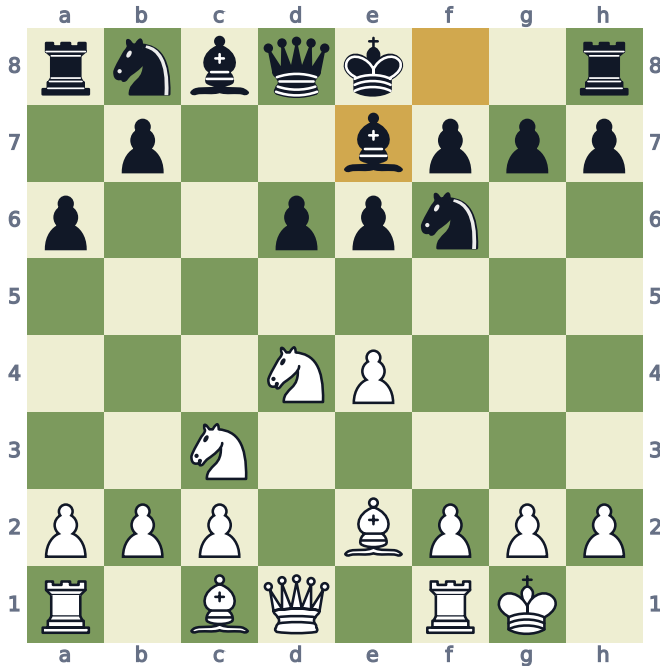
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e6 7. O-O Be7 8. f4 Qc7 9. Kh1 O-O 10. a4 Nc6



- Nc3: White reroutes a knight to c3; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
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- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
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WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

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ANSWER KEY

1. Queenside expansion is useful when it gains space, drives a piece, supports ...Bb7, or creates a file; otherwise it may expose b6 and a6. 2. Prepare ...b5 with piece control, king safety, and an answer to e5 or a4; use ...b4 only when the knight displacement matters. 3. White restrains with a4 or opens the center while Black spends tempi on pawns. 4. If ...b5 is played, what concrete improvement arrives on the next move? 5. Treating ...b5 as a compulsory Najdorf badge rather than a calculated operation.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e6 7. O-O Be7

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: When ...b5 is real



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



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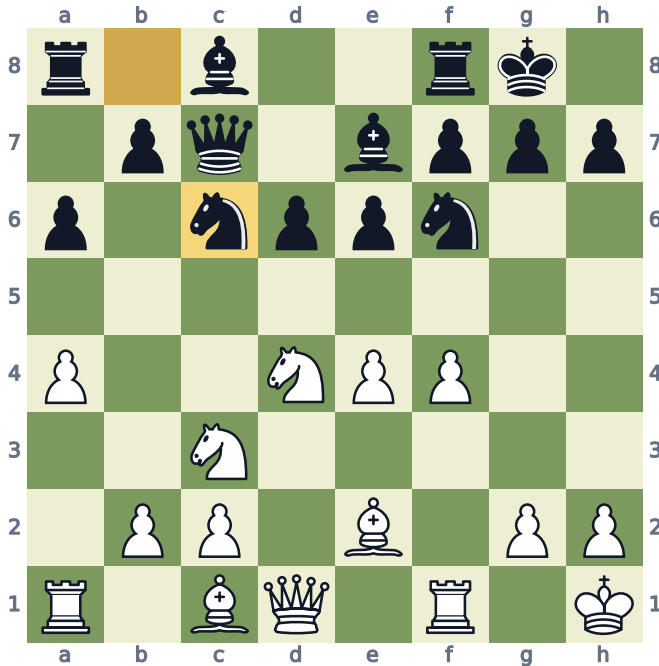
RULE | A wing pawn move must buy time, a square, or a file.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e6 7. O-O Be7 8. f4 Qc7 9. Kh1 O-O 10. a4 Nc6



- f4: White claims kingside space and announces e5 or f5 attacking ideas.
- Qc7: Black coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.
- Kh1: White improves coordination and changes the candidate set.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- a4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight to c6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Queenside expansion is useful when it gains space, drives a piece, supports ...Bb7, or creates a file; otherwise it may expose b6 and a6.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

If ...b5 is played, what concrete improvement arrives on the next move? White's resistance is: White restrains with a4 or opens the center while Black spends tempi on pawns. The line fails as a template when: Treating ...b5 as a compulsory Najdorf badge rather than a calculated operation.

STORE THIS | A wing pawn move must buy time, a square, or a file.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Queenside expansion is useful when it gains space, drives a piece, supports ...Bb7, or creates a file; otherwise it may expose b6 and a6. 2. Prepare ...b5 with piece control, king safety, and an answer to e5 or a4; use ...b4 only when the knight displacement matters. 3. White restrains with a4 or opens the center while Black spends tempi on pawns. 4. If ...b5 is played, what concrete improvement arrives on the next move? 5. Treating ...b5 as a compulsory Najdorf badge rather than a calculated operation.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 20 plies from memory, then replay: 8. f4 Qc7 9. Kh1 O-O 10. a4 Nc6

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 019 Decode: The meaning of 5...a6

Prompt: What did White's sixth move reveal about castling, pawn breaks, and the critical central response?

Recall: ...a6 asks White to declare a plan; Black's next move must answer that declaration.

LESSON 020 Play: The meaning of 5...a6

Prompt: What did White's sixth move reveal about castling, pawn breaks, and the critical central response?

Recall: ...a6 asks White to declare a plan; Black's next move must answer that declaration.

LESSON 021 Decode: Choosing between ...e6 and ...e5

Prompt: Which structure gives your pieces active squares while denying White a favorable break?

Recall: The central pawn decides the whole position; choose it after reading the pieces.

LESSON 022 Play: Choosing between ...e6 and ...e5

Prompt: Which structure gives your pieces active squares while denying White a favorable break?

Recall: The central pawn decides the whole position; choose it after reading the pieces.

LESSON 023 Decode: When ...b5 is real

Prompt: If ...b5 is played, what concrete improvement arrives on the next move?

Recall: A wing pawn move must buy time, a square, or a file.

LESSON 024 Play: When ...b5 is real

Prompt: If ...b5 is played, what concrete improvement arrives on the next move?

Recall: A wing pawn move must buy time, a square, or a file.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

The meaning of 5...a6

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be3 e6 7. Qd2 b5

Decision: What did White's sixth move reveal about castling, pawn breaks, and the critical central response?

Memory: ...a6 asks White to declare a plan; Black's next move must answer that declaration.

CARD 2

Choosing between ...e6 and ...e5

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e5 7. Nb3 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. f4 Be6

Decision: Which structure gives your pieces active squares while denying White a favorable break?

Memory: The central pawn decides the whole position; choose it after reading the pieces.

CARD 3

When ...b5 is real

1. e4 c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 a6 6. Be2 e6 7. O-O Be7 8. f4 Qc7 9. Kh1 O-O 10. a4 Nc6

Decision: If ...b5 is played, what concrete improvement arrives on the next move?

Memory: A wing pawn move must buy time, a square, or a file.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
019 Decode: The meaning of 5...a6	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
020 Play: The meaning of 5...a6	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
021 Decode: Choosing between ...e6 and ...e5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
022 Play: Choosing between ...e6 and ...e5	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
023 Decode: When ...b5 is real	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
024 Play: When ...b5 is real	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.